A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

The Book in the Rubble

A sermon on Huldah

THE BIG IDEA

The word of God found in the rubble wounds the proud, hears the humble, and points to the King who took its curse: Huldah spoke the word, Josiah reformed the nation, and Jesus bore the judgment.

PRIMARY TEXT	2 Kings 22:14–20
ALSO READ	2 Kings 22:1–23:30; 2 Chronicles 34:1–33; Deuteronomy 28–29; Jeremiah 31:31–34; Galatians 3:10–14
TIME	55–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response.

Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.

A COMPLETE MANUSCRIPT FOR THE PULPIT

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Introduction: The book in the rubble

There are finds that change a life, and finds that change a nation. This is the second kind.

The year is around 622 BC. Judah is a small kingdom wedged between Egypt and the dying giant of Assyria. The temple in Jerusalem is nearly three and a half centuries old, and it has survived worse than age. Manasseh, the king before last, reigned fifty-five years and turned the house of the LORD into a showcase for other gods: an Asherah pole in the temple, altars to the host of heaven in its courts, his own son through the fire. By the time his grandson Josiah takes the throne, the building is standing but the worship is a wreck.

Josiah is eight years old when he becomes king. Eight. He inherits a cabinet, a capital, and a religion he did not choose. And yet the text says something remarkable about him: "He did what was right in the eyes of the LORD and walked in all the way of David his father, and he did not turn aside to the right or to the left" (2 Kings 22:2). By the eighteenth year of his reign he is twenty-six, and he decides the temple needs repair. He sends Shaphan the secretary to Hilkiah the high priest with instructions: count the money, pay the workmen, buy timber and stone, fix the house. No accounting is required from the workmen, "for they deal honestly" (22:7). It is a building project. It is administration. It is the kind of chapter most of us skip.

Then a sentence arrives that has echoed for twenty-six centuries: "And Hilkiah the high priest said to Shaphan the secretary, 'I have found the Book of the Law in the house of the LORD.' And Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan, and he read it" (22:8).

The Book of the Law. In the house of the LORD. Found.

We do not know exactly what the scroll contained. Most scholars identify it with Deuteronomy or a core of Deuteronomy; the reform that follows has Deuteronomy's fingerprints all over it: one place of worship, a covenant, a Passover unlike any in living memory. But the text gives no table of contents, and we should not pretend it does. What it gives is enough: the book was there, and the book had been lost.

That is the first shock of this story. The book was in the house of God, and the people of God had been living without it. It was not in a museum or on a shelf. It was somewhere in the clutter and dust of a building under repair. And when it was found, the king did not say, "Great, put it back." He tore his clothes.

That is not a small gesture. In the ancient world, tearing your garments was what you did when you heard news of a death, a disaster, a blasphemy. It was public grief. It was the body saying

what the mouth could not. The king of Judah, the son of David, hears the book read and falls apart.

Why? Because he understood what he was hearing. The book was not a collection of ancient inspiration. It was a covenant document, and it came with blessings and curses. "But if you will not obey the voice of the LORD your God or be careful to do all his commandments and his statutes that I command you today, then all these curses shall come upon you and overtake you" (Deuteronomy 28:15). The book told him what happens when a nation breaks its covenant with God. And as Shaphan read, the king realized that the nation had broken it.

The word of God does that. It does not arrive as a compliment. It arrives as a verdict. It tells us who we are and who we have been, and it does not wait for our permission. The king heard it and tore his clothes. We hear it and reach for a pen to edit it, or look for a way to make it about someone else, or say, "That was a different culture." The king heard it and fell apart.

This is the first lesson of the book in the rubble: the word of God is not a mirror for self-improvement. It is a verdict, and the only sane response to a verdict is repentance.

But the story does not end with a king in tears. It ends with a nation on its feet. And between the tears and the reform, there is a woman most of us have never heard of.

Her name is Huldah.

She lives in the Second Quarter of Jerusalem. She is a prophetess. And when the king sends his men to inquire of the LORD, they go to her.

That is where we are going. We will look at the king who tore his clothes, the woman in the Second Quarter, the word she spoke, the reform that followed, and the judgment that did not turn away. And we will look past both king and prophetess to the King who took the curse.

Because the book in the rubble is not finally about a scroll. It is about a word that finds us, wounds us, hears us, and saves us.

Let us read the story.

Movement 1: The king who tore his clothes

To feel the weight of this story, you have to understand how bad things had been.

Josiah's grandfather Manasseh is the villain of the book of Kings. His reign is described in 2 Kings 21 with a list of horrors: he rebuilt the high places his father Hezekiah had destroyed, he

erected altars for Baal, he made an Asherah, he worshiped all the host of heaven, he built altars in the house of the LORD, he burned his son as an offering, he practiced fortune-telling and divination, he shed innocent blood until Jerusalem was full of it. The text says he "led them astray to do more evil than the nations had done whom the LORD destroyed before the people of Israel" (2 Kings 21:9). His son Amon followed him and was assassinated after two years. Then the people of the land put an eight-year-old on the throne.

That is the world Josiah inherited. A temple with idols in it. A priesthood that had learned to coexist. A nation that had forgotten what the covenant required. And a king who was, as far as the record goes, trying to do right.

The reform did not begin with the book. The book was found because the reform had begun. Josiah set out to repair the temple, and the repair is what uncovered the scroll. That is worth noticing. God's word was not found by a king who was looking for a revelation. It was found by a king who was doing maintenance. It was found in the middle of an ordinary, expensive, unglamorous act of obedience.

You may meet God in the same place. Not always on the mountaintop, not always in a crisis. Sometimes the word finds you while you are doing the dishes, showing up to the job, repairing what is broken. The temple repair looked like a budget line. It was the doorway to revival.

Shaphan the secretary takes the book back to the king and reads it aloud. We do not know how much he read. We do not know whether he read the blessings first or the curses, the covenant or the warnings. But we know what landed. When the king heard the words of the Book of the Law, he tore his clothes.

Look at his next move. He does not call a committee. He does not order a new translation. He does not ask whether the scroll is authentic. He sends a delegation to inquire of the LORD. "Go, inquire of the LORD for me, and for the people, and for all Judah, concerning the words of this book that has been found. For great is the wrath of the LORD that is kindled against us, because our fathers have not obeyed the words of this book, to do according to all that is written concerning us" (2 Kings 22:13).

That is a remarkable sentence. "For me, and for the people, and for all Judah." The king does not separate himself from the nation. He does not say, "I was only eight when this started." He does not blame Manasseh. He includes himself in the guilt of the covenant people. That is what real repentance sounds like. It does not calculate percentages of blame. It says, "We have sinned."

And notice what he is afraid of. He is not afraid of Assyria. He is not afraid of Egypt. He is not afraid of the economy. He is afraid of the book. He has read the covenant curses, and he believes them. He believes that the God who made the covenant is alive, that He keeps His word, and that a nation which has broken the covenant is in danger. The king's theology is not sophisticated, but it is sound: God means what He says.

That is the first thing this text asks of us. Do we believe the book? Not do we own it, quote it, or defend it. Do we believe it enough to be afraid of what it says about us? The king had a scroll he had never read, and when he read it, it broke him. Many of us have a book we have read many times, and it has stopped breaking us. We have reduced it to principles for a better life and forgotten that it is the word of the living God, "living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword" (Hebrews 4:12).

The king tore his clothes. Then he sent for someone who could tell him what God was saying.

He sent for Huldah.

Movement 2: The woman in the Second Quarter

The delegation is worth reading slowly. "So Hilkiah the priest, and Ahikam, and Achbor, and Shaphan, and Asaiah went to Huldah the prophetess, the wife of Shallum the son of Tikvah, son of Harhas, keeper of the wardrobe (now she lived in Jerusalem in the Second Quarter), and they talked with her" (2 Kings 22:14).

Five men. The high priest. The king's secretary. The king's servant. Two senior officials. This is the cabinet of Judah, walking across the city to talk to a woman.

The text does not make a speech about it. It does not say, "Can you believe they went to a woman?" It simply records the fact, and the fact is meant to be noticed. The official channels of religious authority were male. And here, at the hinge of the nation's history, the word of the LORD comes through a woman in the newer part of town.

Who is Huldah?

She is called a prophetess. That is not a courtesy title. In the Old Testament, a prophetess speaks for God. Miriam is called a prophetess (Exodus 15:20). Deborah is called a prophetess (Judges 4:4). Isaiah's wife is called the prophetess (Isaiah 8:3). And Huldah is called a prophetess here. There are not many of them, and the text does not treat the title as an anomaly. It treats it as a fact.

She is married to Shallum, son of Tikvah, son of Harhas, keeper of the wardrobe. We do not know whether this was the royal wardrobe or the priests', but it was a court position, a position of trust. Huldah is no hermit in the desert. She is a married woman in the capital, connected to the life of the kingdom, with a ministry of her own.

She lives in the Second Quarter. The Hebrew word is Mishneh, the "second" or "new" district. Many scholars identify it with the newer western hill of Jerusalem, the part of the city that had expanded outside the old walls, perhaps in the days of Hezekiah. The archaeology of the Broad Wall and the houses of that district fits the picture: a growing city, crowded with refugees and merchants and craftsmen, a place where the old certainties were being stretched.

Why does the text tell us where she lived? Maybe because the location matters. The word of the LORD did not come from the palace or the temple. It came from the Second Quarter, the newer, less established part of the city. God's word is not tied to the real estate we consider holy. It is tied to the God who speaks.

And here is the thing that should stop us: Huldah is not impressed by the delegation.

When the men arrive, she does not curtsy. She does not say, "I am not qualified." She does not ask her husband to handle it. She does not hedge. She says, "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel: Tell the man who sent you to me" (2 Kings 22:15).

"Tell the man." Not "tell his majesty." Not "tell the king." The man. She speaks to Josiah as a human being under the word of God. That is not disrespect. It is perspective. The king is a man. The book is the book. And the God who wrote it is not impressed by crowns.

This is what authority looks like when it is borrowed. Huldah has no army, no throne, no official office. She has a word from the LORD. And because she has that word, she can stand in front of the high priest and the king's cabinet and speak with a steadiness that no palace could give her.

There is a lesson here for anyone who has ever felt disqualified from speaking for God. Huldah was not a priest, a queen, or a court prophet. She was a woman in the Second Quarter with a husband and a word. And the word was enough.

But there is a deeper lesson, and it is not about Huldah's qualifications. It is about God's freedom. He spoke through a donkey to Balaam, through a pagan king named Cyrus, through a child named Samuel, through a woman in the Second Quarter. And He spoke through His Son. The question is never whether the messenger fits our expectations. The question is whether the message is from God.

That is why the delegation's visit is not a footnote. It is a test of the king's humility. Josiah could have sent only the high priest. He could have sent only the scholars. He could have sent to a prophet he had heard of. He sent to Huldah. He was willing to hear the word from whoever God sent. That willingness is part of what made him a reformer.

And that is a question for us: Are we willing to hear the word from the person God actually sent? Not the person we would have chosen, not the platform we admire, not the voice that sounds like ours. The word of God often comes through the unexpected messenger, and our pride is often what keeps us from hearing it.

Huldah speaks. And what she says is not what the king wants to hear.

Movement 3: The word she spoke

Huldah's oracle has two halves, and we need to hear both.

The first half is judgment. "Thus says the LORD, Behold, I will bring disaster upon this place and upon its inhabitants, all the words of the book that the king of Judah has read. Because they have forsaken me and have made offerings to other gods, that they might provoke me to anger with all the works of their hands, therefore my wrath will be poured out on this place and will not be quenched" (2 Kings 22:16–17).

This is not a gentle word. It is not the word we would have written for a young king trying to do right. It is a word of certain judgment, grounded in the book itself. Huldah is not inventing a message. She is applying the covenant curses to the covenant people. The book said what would happen, and the book was right.

Notice what she says about the temple. "This place." The temple is where God put His name, the place of sacrifice and prayer and the ark. And Huldah says the wrath of God will be poured out on this place and will not be quenched. The temple is not a talisman. It does not protect the people who desecrate it. Jeremiah will say the same a generation later: "Do not trust in deceptive words, saying, 'This is the temple of the LORD'" (Jeremiah 7:4). A building is not a savior. A ritual is not a savior. The presence of God is not a good-luck charm.

The reason for the judgment is not mysterious. "Because they have forsaken me and have made offerings to other gods." The nation had broken the first commandment, trading the living God for idols. The wrath of God is not a temper tantrum. It is the settled opposition of a holy God to sin, the covenant consequence the book itself predicted.

We like the God who forgives. We do not like the God who says, "My wrath will be poured out on this place and will not be quenched." But the two are the same God. The God who loves is against everything that destroys what He loves. A God who is indifferent to evil is not loving; He is passive.

Huldah does not soften the judgment. She does not say, "It's not as bad as it sounds," or, "God is love, so He will overlook it." She says what God says. And the king, to his credit, had already torn his clothes because he believed it.

Then comes the second half of the oracle, and it is a surprise. "But to the king of Judah, who sent you to inquire of the LORD, thus shall you say to him, Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel: Regarding the words that you have heard, because your heart was tender and you humbled yourself before the LORD, when you heard how I spoke against this place and against its inhabitants, that they should become a desolation and a curse, and you have torn your clothes and wept before me, I also have heard you, declares the LORD. Therefore, behold, I will gather you to your fathers, and you shall be gathered to your grave in peace, and your eyes shall not see all the disaster that I will bring upon this place" (2 Kings 22:18–20).

The nation is still going into judgment. But the king is heard.

Why? "Because your heart was tender." That is the ground. Not because Josiah had a plan. Not because he was a good king. Not because he was David's descendant. Because his heart was tender, and he humbled himself, and he wept.

The Hebrew word for "tender" is rakh. It means soft, pliable, easily moved. It is the opposite of a hard heart. A tender heart is a heart that can still be wounded by the word. A hard heart has learned to deflect it. A tender heart hears the sentence and feels its weight. A hard heart hears the sentence and starts arguing about the translation.

There is a whole theology in that word. God looks to the one who is "humble and contrite in spirit and trembles at my word" (Isaiah 66:2). David prays, "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise" (Psalm 51:17). The tender heart is not weak. It is alive to God, and it is the heart God can work with.

And notice what God says: "I also have heard you." The king had said, "Inquire of the LORD for me." God says, "I have heard you." The judgment is corporate, but the king's cry is heard by name. That is the kindness of God in the middle of a disaster. He does not owe it. He gives it.

Now, what about the promise? "You shall be gathered to your fathers, and you shall be gathered to your grave in peace, and your eyes shall not see all the disaster that I will bring upon this place."

It sounds like a promise of a peaceful death. But that is not how it turned out. Josiah died at Megiddo, in battle, at thirty-nine. Pharaoh Neco of Egypt was passing through on his way to the Euphrates, and Josiah went out to meet him, and Neco killed him (2 Kings 23:29). His servants brought his body back in a chariot and buried him in his own tomb (23:30). Jeremiah lamented for him (2 Chronicles 35:25). That is not a quiet death in bed.

So was Huldah wrong?

No. Read it carefully. It does not say, "You will die in peace." It says, "You shall be gathered to your grave in peace, and your eyes shall not see all the disaster." The promise was kept in its own terms. Josiah was buried with his fathers, in his own tomb, before the city fell. He did not see the walls breached, the temple burn, or the exile. The judgment he feared came after he was gone.

That is sobering, and it is true. God's promises are often more precise than our expectations, and sometimes more limited. He did not promise Josiah a long life or a painless road. He promised him a grave in peace. The mercy was real. It was just not the mercy Josiah might have written for himself.

There is a pastoral word here for anyone who has prayed for a stay of judgment and received one smaller than they hoped. God hears. But His answers are shaped by His wisdom, not our scripts. He may spare you from seeing the thing you fear while the larger story runs its course. That is not abandonment. That is mercy with a longer view.

Huldah spoke both halves: the judgment that was certain and the mercy that was personal. She did not soften the first or universalize the second. She spoke what God gave her and left the results to God. That is what a faithful prophet does—and a faithful preacher. We are not called to make the word more acceptable. We are called to say what God says.

Movement 4: The reform that could not save

The rest of 2 Kings 22 and 23 is the story of Josiah's reform. It is one of the most thorough religious clean-ups in the Bible.

The king gathers all the elders of Judah and Jerusalem. He goes up to the house of the LORD with the men of Judah, the priests, the prophets, and all the people. He reads in their hearing all the words of the Book of the Covenant. Then he stands by the pillar and makes a covenant before the LORD: to walk after the LORD, to keep His commandments and testimonies and statutes with all his heart and all his soul, to perform the words of the covenant written in the book. And all the people join in the covenant (2 Kings 23:1–3).

Then the purge begins. The vessels made for Baal and Asherah and the host of heaven are brought out of the temple and burned. The idolatrous priests are deposed. The Asherah is dragged out, burned, ground to powder, and thrown on the graves of the common people. The horses and chariots of the sun are removed. The altars on the roof and in the courts are broken down and their dust thrown into the Kidron. The altar at Bethel, the one Jeroboam built, is torn down and burned. It is a comprehensive, deliberate dismantling of a century of idolatry.

And then the positive side: "And the king commanded all the people, 'Keep the Passover to the LORD your God, as it is written in this Book of the Covenant.' No such Passover had been kept since the days of the judges who judged Israel, or during all the days of the kings of Israel and the kings of Judah" (2 Kings 23:21–22). The reform is not only about tearing down. It is about restoring worship. The king does not just remove the false; he rebuilds the true.

The verdict on Josiah is one of the highest in the Old Testament: "Before him there was no king like him, who turned to the LORD with all his heart and with all his soul and with all his might, according to all the Law of Moses, and after him none arose like him" (2 Kings 23:25).

That is the high point. That is the best a king of Judah ever got. And then comes the sentence that makes the whole story tremble: "Still the LORD did not turn from the burning of his great wrath, by which his anger was kindled against Judah, because of all the provocations with which Manasseh had provoked him" (2 Kings 23:26).

The reform was real. The covenant was renewed. The idols were gone. The Passover was kept. And the judgment still came.

Why?

The text gives one reason: Manasseh. The sins of a previous generation had filled the cup, and the nation had not turned from them in its heart, even if its king had. The reform was top-down. The people joined the covenant, but the text does not say their hearts were changed. They were obeying the king, not necessarily loving the LORD.

But there is a deeper reason, and the rest of the Bible makes it plain. The law cannot save by being obeyed, because the law was never designed to save. It was designed to show us what God requires and to expose our inability to meet it. Paul says it like this: "For all who rely on works of the law are under a curse; for it is written, 'Cursed be everyone who does not abide by all things written in the Book of the Law, and do them.' Now it is evident that no one is justified before God by the law, for 'The righteous shall live by faith.' The law is not of faith, rather 'The one who does them shall live by them.' Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us" (Galatians 3:10–13).

That is the answer to the riddle of Josiah. The best reform in Judah's history could not turn away the wrath, because the problem was not merely the idols on the high places. The problem was the human heart. You can tear down every altar and still have a heart bent away from God. You can keep the Passover and still not love the One you are worshiping. The law can restrain sin. It cannot regenerate the sinner.

This is why the prophets after Josiah do not say, "If we just had a better king, a stricter reform, a more faithful Passover, everything would be fine." They say the opposite. Jeremiah announces a new covenant: "For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, declares the LORD: I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people" (Jeremiah 31:33). Ezekiel promises a new heart: "And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules" (Ezekiel 36:26–27).

The problem with Judah was not the absence of a book. The book had been found. The problem was the absence of a heart that could keep it. And that is the problem with us.

We can reform our lives. We can clean up our habits, join a church, read the Bible, serve the poor, keep the rules. And none of it can turn away the wrath our sin deserves, because the reform is still ours. It is still the work of a heart not naturally inclined to God. The law shows us the shape of righteousness, but it cannot give us the life to live it.

That is why the next movement of this sermon is not "try harder." It is "look to the King."

Movement 5: The King who took the curse

The Bible is not a collection of moral examples. It is a story that leads to a person. And the story of Huldah and Josiah leads to Jesus.

Think about what Josiah did. He read the book. He tore his clothes. He made a covenant. He cleansed the temple. He kept the Passover. He turned to the LORD with all his heart and soul and might. And he could not save his nation. He could not even save himself from an arrow at Megiddo.

Now think about what Jesus did. He is the true King of David's line, the one who did what Josiah could only point to. He read the book in the synagogue and said, "Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing" (Luke 4:21). He kept the law perfectly, not just outwardly but in His heart. He cleansed the temple, and when they asked for a sign, He said, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up" (John 2:19). He kept the Passover with His disciples, and then He became the Passover lamb: "Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed" (1 Corinthians 5:7). He is the Prophet like Moses, the one God promised to raise up, the one we must listen to (Deuteronomy 18:15; Acts 3:22).

And here is the heart of it: He took the curse.

The book that Josiah read pronounced a curse on everyone who did not keep all its words. Josiah kept more of it than any king before him, and he still could not remove the curse. Jesus came under the curse in our place. "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us—for it is written, 'Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree'" (Galatians 3:13). He was hanged on a tree. He bore the wrath that Huldah announced. He drank the cup that the book of curses had filled. "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21).

That is the answer to the judgment that would not be quenched. The wrath of God against sin was not ignored. It was poured out on His Son. The cross is where the book's curse fell, and the empty tomb is where the curse was broken. "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1). Not because we kept the book, but because He did, and because He took what we deserved.

And the new heart that Jeremiah and Ezekiel promised? Jesus gives it. He sends the Spirit, who writes the law on the inside and changes the want-to. "For God has done what the law, weakened by the flesh, could not do. By sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and for sin, he condemned sin in the flesh, in order that the righteous requirement of the law might

be fulfilled in us, who walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit" (Romans 8:3–4).

This is why the gospel is not "be like Josiah." Josiah is a hero, and we should admire him. But Josiah cannot save us. He could not save Judah. He cannot save you. The best king in Judah's history died in battle and was buried in a tomb, and the city fell anyway. The greater King died on a cross and was buried in a borrowed tomb, and on the third day the tomb was empty.

Huldah spoke the word of the LORD to a king. Jesus is the Word of the LORD made flesh (John 1:14). Huldah's word was true, and it wounded and it healed. Jesus is the truth, and He wounds and He heals. She pointed to the judgment and the mercy. He bore the judgment and became the mercy.

So the question this text puts to you is not, "Have you read the book?" It is, "Have you come to the King?" You can own a Bible and still be under the curse. You can memorize it, defend it, preach it, and never submit to the One it speaks of. Jesus said to the religious leaders of His day, "You search the Scriptures because you think that in them you have eternal life; and it is they that bear witness about me, yet you refuse to come to me that you may have life" (John 5:39–40).

The book in the rubble was never the destination. It was the signpost. And the signpost points to the cross.

Application: What do you do with a book that finds you?

So what do we do with this story? Let me give you four responses.

1. Let the Word wound you before it comforts you.

The king heard the book and tore his clothes. He did not rush to the promises. He did not skip to the part where God is love. He let the verdict land. And that is where real faith begins.

We are good at skipping to comfort. We read a passage that exposes us and immediately say, "But God forgives." True—but it is not the first word. The first word is the verdict. Forgiveness is precious only when you know what you are forgiven for. Let the Word wound you. Let it name your sin. The tenderness that saves is the tenderness that first bleeds.

2. Bring your fear to the place where God speaks.

Josiah did not keep his fear to himself. He sent for the word of the LORD. He did not ask his advisors to manage the crisis. He went to the prophet. He wanted to know what God said.

What do you do when the Word exposes you? Hide? Rationalize? Distract yourself? Or go to the place where God speaks? That place is not a building. It is the Word read and preached and prayed, among the people of God. Go there. Do not let fear drive you from the only voice that can answer it.

3. Do not despise the messenger.

The king sent his cabinet to a woman in the Second Quarter. He did not demand that God speak through the channels he expected. He went where the word was.

God still speaks through unexpected people. Through the friend who tells you the truth you did not want to hear. Through the older saint who has walked with God longer than you have. Through the child who asks the question you cannot answer. Through the preacher whose style is not yours. Through the stranger whose accent and background and politics are not like yours. The question is not whether the messenger fits your brand. The question is whether the message is true. Test it by the book. But do not let your pride keep you from hearing the word of the LORD.

4. Do not stop at mourning; do the reform.

Josiah did not just tear his clothes. He made a covenant. He cleansed the temple. He restored the Passover. He did the work. His mourning became obedience.

There is a kind of repentance that is all tears and no action. It feels deep, but it changes nothing. The Bible calls it worldly grief, the kind that produces death (2 Corinthians 7:10). Godly grief produces a change. If the Word has shown you a sin, do not just feel bad about it. Put it away. If it has shown you a neglected duty, do it. If it has shown you a relationship to repair, repair it. Mourning is the doorway. Reform is the room.

But remember: the reform is not the savior. Josiah's reform could not save him, and yours cannot save you. Do the work because you are saved, not in order to be saved. The order matters: grace, then obedience. The gospel is not "clean up and come." It is "come, and I will clean you up."

The invitation

There are three people in this room, and this story is for all of them.

The first has been reading the Bible for years without hearing it. You know the stories, you can quote the verses, but the book has become furniture. It is on your shelf, on your phone, in your head, and it has not broken your heart in a long time. The king had a scroll he had never read, and it broke him. Come to the Word again, not as a text to master but as a voice to obey.

The second has been hiding from the book because you are afraid of what it will say. You know there is something in your life that the Word condemns. You have been keeping it at arm's length. You have been telling yourself that God is love and that He understands. He does understand. He also speaks. The king was afraid, and he went to the prophet anyway. That is the way through. Do not let fear keep you from the only word that can heal you.

The third has torn your clothes but never come to the King. You have mourned your sin. You have felt the weight of it. You have tried to reform. You have cleaned up, started over, promised better, failed again. You are still under the curse, because you are still trying to pay a debt you cannot pay. The book cannot save you. The reform cannot save you. The King can. Jesus took the curse. He drank the cup. He rose from the dead. Come to Him.

The invitation is not "be a better Josiah." It is "come to the greater King." The book in the rubble points to the cross. The prophetess in the Second Quarter points to the Prophet who is the Word made flesh. The reform that could not save points to the Savior who did.

His name is Jesus. He saves.

Response

Take a moment of silence. Let the Word settle.

Here are three questions to take into the silence.

First: What has the Word shown you about yourself this week that you have been avoiding? Name it before God. Do not explain it. Do not defend it. Name it.

Second: Who is the messenger you have been dismissing? Is there someone God has sent to speak truth into your life, and you have refused to listen because of who they are, or because of how they said it? Ask God for the humility to hear.

Third: What reform is the Word asking of you? Not a vague intention. A concrete act. A habit to put away. A relationship to repair. A step of obedience. What is it?

In a moment, I will invite you to do one thing this week. Not ten. One. Write it down. Tell someone. Do it.

A word of care. If the Word has surfaced something painful in your past—abuse, harm, a hidden wound—do not rush into "reform" language as if the burden were yours alone. God is not indifferent to what was done to you. The psalms are full of lament, and the Lord is near to the brokenhearted (Psalm 34:18). Please speak to a pastor or trusted counselor. Safety and care come first.

Let us pray.

"Lord, your word is true, and we are not. We have heard it and argued with it. We have read it and ignored it. We have sung it and forgotten it. Give us tender hearts. Give us the humility of Josiah, who tore his clothes and sent for the word. Give us the courage of Huldah, who spoke what you gave her. And give us the grace to come to the King who took the curse, Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen."

Closing

The book was found in a building under repair. A king tore his clothes. A prophetess in the Second Quarter spoke the word of the LORD. A nation reformed, and judgment still came. And beyond it all, a greater King stood waiting.

The book found Josiah. The King finds us.

The word that wounds is the word that heals. The curse that fell is the curse He carried. The grave that opened is the grave He emptied.

Go and live under the book. Go and bow before the King.

May the same be said of us.

Evidence note for the preacher

The text. The primary narrative is 2 Kings 22:14–20, with the discovery and reform in 2 Kings 22:1–23:30. The parallel is 2 Chronicles 34:1–33, which places the finding in the eighteenth year of Josiah and gives a slightly different sequence: Chronicles has Josiah begin seeking the LORD in

the eighth year of his reign and purging Judah in the twelfth year (34:3–7), before the temple repair and the discovery. Kings narrates the finding first and the reform after. The sermon follows the Kings sequence and notes Chronicles' ordering where it matters. The "Book of the Law" is widely identified with Deuteronomy or a core of it; the reform's centralization of worship, covenant renewal, and Passover have Deuteronomy's shape. The text does not specify the extent of the scroll, and the sermon should not claim more than that.

Huldah. She is called a prophetess (2 Kings 22:14). She is the wife of Shallum son of Tikvah son of Harhas, "keeper of the wardrobe" (2 Kings 22:14); the text does not say whether this was the royal or priestly wardrobe. She lived in Jerusalem in the Second Quarter (Mishneh), likely the newer western district of the city; many scholars connect it with the eighth-century expansion of Jerusalem under Hezekiah, but the text does not describe the neighborhood. Rabbinic tradition (b. Megillah 14b) links Huldah's family to Joshua and Rahab; these are later traditions, not canonical, and should be labeled as such if mentioned at all. The narrative does not comment on her gender; it simply records that the king's delegation went to her. The sermon may note the significance without turning it into a slogan.

The oracle. Huldah's word has two parts: judgment on "this place" and its inhabitants (2 Kings 22:16–17), and mercy for Josiah because his heart was tender and he humbled himself (22:18–20). The judgment is grounded in "all the words of the book" (22:16), not in a new revelation; Huldah applies the covenant curses. The mercy is personal, not a general amnesty. The promise that Josiah would be "gathered to your grave in peace" (22:20) must be read alongside 2 Kings 23:29–30: he died in battle at Megiddo at thirty-nine and was buried in his own tomb. The promise was kept in its own terms—he was buried before the disaster and did not see Jerusalem fall—but it was not a promise of a long, painless life. Do not turn it into a prosperity promise.

The reform and the wrath. 2 Kings 23:1–25 records the covenant, the purge, and the Passover. The verdict "before him there was no king like him" (23:25) is the highest royal commendation in Kings. Yet 2 Kings 23:26–27 says the LORD did not turn from His great wrath because of Manasseh's provocations, and the exile followed. The theological point is not that reform was useless; it is that law-keeping cannot atone for covenant-breaking. The new covenant promises a new heart and the law written within (Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 36:25–27), and the New Testament identifies Jesus as the one who redeems from the curse of the law (Galatians 3:10–14; 2 Corinthians 5:21; Romans 8:1–4).

The gospel. The sermon's typology is modest. Josiah is a signpost, not a direct prophecy: a faithful king who could not save his people. Jesus is the greater King who kept the law, bore its curse, and rose again. Huldah is a faithful prophetess; Jesus is the Word made flesh (John 1:14) and the Prophet like Moses (Deuteronomy 18:15; Acts 3:22–26). Do not claim that Huldah predicted Jesus by name or that the "Second Quarter" carries a hidden messianic meaning.

Confidence. Strong for the narrative sequence, Huldah's oracle, and the reform's outline. Moderate for the identification of the book with Deuteronomy and for the location of the Second Quarter. The sermon should use "widely identified" and "likely" where the evidence is not explicit, and should not invent the discovery scene, Huldah's biography, or the details of Josiah's death beyond the text.